UNIVERSITY OF CALIFORNIA, LOS ANGELES

UCLA

BERKELEY • DAVIS • IRVINE • LOS ANGELES • MERCED • RIVERSIDE • SAN DIEGO • SAN FRANCISCO

SANTA BARBARA • SANTA CRUZ

UCLA INSTITUTE OF THE ENVIRONMENT AND SUSTAINABILITY
LA KRETZ HALL, SUITE 300
619 CHARLES E. YOUNG DR. EAST
BOX 951496
LOS ANGELES, CA 90095-1496

PHONE: 310-825-5008
FAX: 310-825-9663
www.environment.ucla.edu

February 4, 2026

Dear UCLA Distinguished Teaching Award Selection Committee Members,

On behalf of the Institute of the Environment & Sustainability, I am pleased to offer my strongest recommendation for **Katherine Hernandez** for the Teaching Assistant Award. Katherine has taught an exceptionally wide range of courses—from essay-based classes in Chicanx literature, film, and environmental narrative to science-heavy courses in global environmental change, urban ecology, biology, GIS labs, and an environmental science senior practicum. Across these contexts, Katherine brings a deeply student-centered, evidence-based approach to teaching that consistently helps students feel more confident, capable, and engaged in their learning.

A key strength of Katherine's teaching is her ability to recognize and address barriers to learning that often go unspoken. Students can arrive at class feeling anxious, overwhelmed, or convinced that school is something to simply endure. Rather than assuming confidence or prior preparation, Katherine works intentionally to reduce fear and uncertainty. She provides clear agendas, transparent expectations, and multiple ways for students to participate, creating an environment where students can focus on learning rather than worrying about performance. This approach is especially impactful in required courses and interdisciplinary classrooms where students may feel unprepared or out of place.

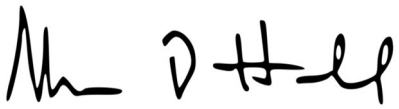
Katherine routinely incorporates research-based teaching strategies into her lessons. In discussion sections, she uses small-group work, collaborative documents, reflective writing, peer teaching, and retrieval-based review activities to strengthen understanding and memory. In one interdisciplinary English course, she designed lesson plans that supported both STEM and humanities students by varying activities, encouraging frequent low-stakes writing, and modeling effective study habits. These strategies helped students build critical reading and writing skills while also learning how to guide their own review and inquiry—skills that extend beyond a single course.

Equally important is Katherine's commitment to inclusive teaching. She is mindful that there is no "average" student and that relying on a single mode of engagement can unintentionally exclude many learners. Her classes offer flexibility, varied learning modalities, and space for reflection, ensuring that students with different backgrounds, confidence levels, and learning styles can participate meaningfully.

Katherine has actively sought opportunities to strengthen her pedagogical knowledge. She draws on formal training through the English Department and continually reflects on what has worked—both for her students and in her own learning experiences—to refine her teaching practices. This ongoing reflection and willingness to adapt are clear markers of an excellent teacher.

It is my honor to write in support of Katherine, whose teaching is marked by extraordinary empathy, intentionality, and a deep faith in every student's ability to succeed. Her approach goes far beyond delivering knowledge; she inspires students to discover their own strengths, nurturing confidence, curiosity, and resilience. Her ability to connect with students on a personal level, paired with her encouragement of authentic creativity, transforms learning into an experience that is both empowering and joyful. Katherine's commitment to helping each student feel seen, valued, and supported makes her not only an exceptional educator but also a valued member of our community. It is with great enthusiasm that I recommend Katherine Hernandez for this award.

Sincerely,



Alex Hall, Ph.D.
Director, UCLA Institute of the Environment and Sustainability

Katherine V. Hernandez

DTA Nominees Statement

February 6, 2026

As a teacher I strive to incorporate evidence-based strategies into all my lesson plans, while making mindful adjustments for the unique challenges each new course presents. My biggest accomplishment is when this strategic effort results students leaving my classroom more confident in their learning than when they entered. While I've taught many classes now and can provide a summary of the years I've spent teaching at UCLA, I believe my value as an educator is best shown through how I run my class sections day-by-day. To foster a strong community among students, I created opportunities for students to connect with each other and myself. For example, one of the first classes I taught was on "Environmental Narrative," where enrollment was split between STEM and humanities majors. As the TA, I was tasked with teaching a unique, interdisciplinary set of materials to students from very different academic backgrounds, using the same materials in the same hour. I also needed to focus on my students' critical writing and reading skills. My weekly lesson plans were designed with these priorities in mind, illustrated best by the slides I made for the course's last discussion section (Artifact 1).

I began each class with an agenda and media recommendations for their curiosity. The former demonstrates instructional transparency, and the latter is to foster students' curiosity and to show them what they're learning has real-world value. Because this was out last class for the quarter, my second slide asks students to complete their TA surveys along with a few guiding questions (Artifact 3). These questions had the additional purpose of moving my students towards a space of reflection. I wanted students to activate and assess their prior knowledge, so I created a group activity where students were asked to discuss in small groups what they remembered from each week of class. I specifically told them not to look anything up because I wanted them to see what they could confidently remember when they didn't have their notes, just like in a final exam.

Students added their answers to our shared google doc (Artifact 2, different course). I create a document like this almost every quarter to offer my students another form of participation. For the average student, talking in class is best, but I never want to accidently exclude some students by only planning for the "average." A class shared document provides students with a TA-monitored space where peer collaboration is encouraged, their learning supplanted with extra activities, and where misinformation can be corrected promptly by me *and* other students.

We always practiced more than just one learning skill in class. On this occasion, students employed active learning strategies on an altered "think-pair-share" activity. When they were done writing down their answers, I asked for volunteers to share some of what they wrote so that I, but mostly their peers, could fill in any content gaps. Teaching someone else is a good way of strengthening your own learning and the "share" part of this activity made room for students to

teach each other. Overall, my goal for this activity was to help students review the course by providing an activity that would guide them to lead their own review.

I left the class with a bit of what I would want after ten weeks of a typically depressing topic (environmental change, environmental inequities, environmental genocide, etc.). I told them it's okay to grieve, rage, and, even still, hope. I gave them my email address with a list of topics I could advise on, and a slide with links to the different orgs, list-servs, archives, and such that I had been sharing each week. Last, I asked my students to do a short write-up, for only themselves, that asked them to reflect on nature, their views, and their own lives now that they've taken this class.

With this course I saw, for the first time, the relief and joy in my students eyes when they finally grasped a concept they had all but given up on. I saw how the quietest students just needed one nod and a "yes, and" to start talking more. The way their writing became for them and not for a grade. These moments are what drive me to improve as a teacher. My students are my biggest accomplishment.

Katherine V. Hernandez

DTA Statement of Teaching Philosophy

February 6, 2026

I have taught a wide variety of subjects while at UCLA. From essay writing-based classes on Chicane literature, film, and environmental narrative, to science-heavy courses on global environmental change, urban ecology, and intro biology. Many students become concerned when they realize their TA is not an expert on what they're teaching. So do TAs, worried they won't be able to serve their students as well as they deserve. I use to have the same anxieties, but since teaching at UCLA this concern has been replaced by the convictions that define my teaching philosophy today.

First, I believe that every human being has a deep need and desire to learn. Unfortunately, we don't all get this need met equally and are not all taught how to satisfy that need for ourselves. My students have jobs. They have families to support. They have worries and limitations and a whole lot of bad experiences that make school feel like something they need to survive rather than a safe place where they get to grow. I want to show my students how to love learning, but I can't do that until the barriers to learning are removed. So, I try to guide my students past their barriers by meeting them where they are, and from there work to foster their curiosity and sense of belonging in the classroom. For example, many students are constantly afraid of their grades, sometimes for very serious reasons like losing one's scholarship or because they are afraid they will fall behind on their dream career if they make any mistakes. In this case, I can help remove that fear by updating grades often and by providing multiple opportunities for students to redeem themselves. I know this strategy works when the questions I receive are content and career-oriented, instead of questions on rubrics, test formatting, and the like.

Second, I aim for all my students to leave my class as more confident learners than before. It is not always clear to students why lessons have been designed the way they are or what purpose their assignments have in teaching them. To this end, I work to be transparent in my instructional plans and make clear which skills we are practicing and why. When teaching an essay-writing course I review with students the skills and purpose of critical reading, for in and outside of the classroom. The skills they learn to spot unreliable narrators will help them spot unreliable writing in their everyday lives. A student who knows the building blocks of a good argument is less likely to be swayed by unsupported, and potentially harmful claims. When students know why and how they are learning, they become more invested in the overall process of learning. These strategies grant students ownership over their education. I know this is happening when the skills we practice in class begin to leak into their peer conversations because students who are confident in their ability to learn and defend their findings will do so on any topic they care about.

Last, as a teacher it is on me to foster a space where students feel safe, welcomed, and strengthened as they learn. The most recent courses I've taught have been centered on the environmental and ecological sciences; this field has historically excluded non-white and low-income peoples from participating, and it is a topic that brings out a lot of dread in my students who have only known a world in ecological disarray. I need my students to know that this knowledge is for them and this world is theirs to change. So, in class I make sure to bring in lesser-known examples from historically marginalized writers, scientists, and other appropriate sources, and explain to my students how I learned about them so they can know how to find and verify knowledge for themselves. When we learn about people or actions with imperfect pasts, I am honest about those pasts and how we can still approach them as scholars. I also start discussion sections with book, movie, video game, and other multi-media recommendations for them to explore on their own. The more I employ these strategies, the more common it is for me to have students ask me for more examples and recommendations related to what they're learning. And the more willing they are to disagree in class discussions. I believe the latter is a good sign because it means they feel safe to argue, respectfully, and trust their peers to counter with respect back.

So, while teaching outside of my area of expertise is a challenge, I face it with no doubt in my abilities because of the convictions that guide me. I regularly return to the roots of my teaching philosophy to make sure that I am also still learning, as an educator, and incorporating new strategies to give my students the classroom experience they deserve. Now, after almost four years of teaching, I can say the students who enter my classroom leave as more curious, confident, and fearless thinkers. To me, that is the success.

Week 10 - Review & Goodbye

Agenda

1) Evals
2) Final Review
   a) Group Activity
   b) Whole-class discussion
3) Beyond this class
4) Extra Time → Office Hours

Last Recommendations

CLIMATE FICTION (Cli-fi)

- "Afterglow: Climate Change for Future Ancestors" by multiple authors
- "Sunvault: Stories of Solarpunk and Eco-Speculation" by multiple authors
- "The Free People's Village" by Sim Kern

ECO-CRITICISM

- "Playing Nature" by Alenda Y. Chang
- "Mourning the Anthropocene" by J. Trey Barnett
- "Arts of Living on a Damaged Planet" by multiple

POETRY

- "Earthrise" poem by Amanda Gorman



Eval Prompts

- What exercises/activities/handouts in section were most helpful for your learning? Why? Any suggestions for improvement?
- How well do you feel that our work in section, office hours, and/or feedback on your writing prepared you for the course assignments? Any suggestions for improvement?
- What is your biggest takeaway from this course (personally, academically, or professionally)?

Final Group Review Activity

On the google doc is a list of the last five weeks of class and their topics. In your group, remember what you can about the week you've been given and write it down. Don't look up details, use this as a way to check what you remember, what you need to review, and which readings you need to look at again.

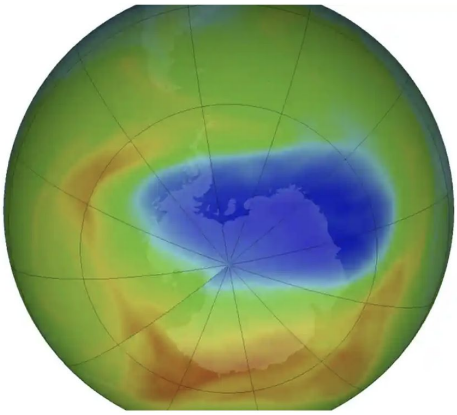
Some questions to ask yourself:

- What got repeated a lot?
- What were the readings? What were the main takeaways for each?
- Which nature perspectives/story-templates/concepts did we focus on this week? What are their key elements?

Climate Grief, Rage, and Hope

Earth's ozone layer on course to be healed within decades, UN report finds

Most of atmospheric layer that protects planet from ultraviolet radiation likely to be fully recovered for most of world by 2040



This image made available by Nasa shows a map of a hole in the ozone layer over Antarctica on 20 October 2019. Photograph: AP

The hole in the Earth's ozone layer, once the most feared environmental peril facing humanity, is set to be completely healed over most of the world within two decades following decisive action by governments to phase out ozone-

Feel things

Do art

Beyond this class

Feel free to email me at kvichernandez@g.ucla.edu for any questions about:

- Grad school
- Working in ecology, conservation, environmental sciences
- Thinking about how we think and talk about the environment
- Finding enviro/eco jobs after college
- Writing fiction, for yourself and/or with the goal to publish
- Science communication and creative nonfiction w/science or enviro foci
- Current discussions on conservation, environmental justice, and the like
- Even more book/game/movie recs and tangents :)

Some Links and Resources (but I have more!)

Writing

https://wp.ucla.edu/undergraduate/undergraduate-writing-center/ | https://www.writersdigest.com/ | https://www.storycollider.org/ | https://www.penguinrandomhouse.com/books/97395/bird-by-bird-by-anne-lamott/

Fiction (sci-fi & fantasy specific)

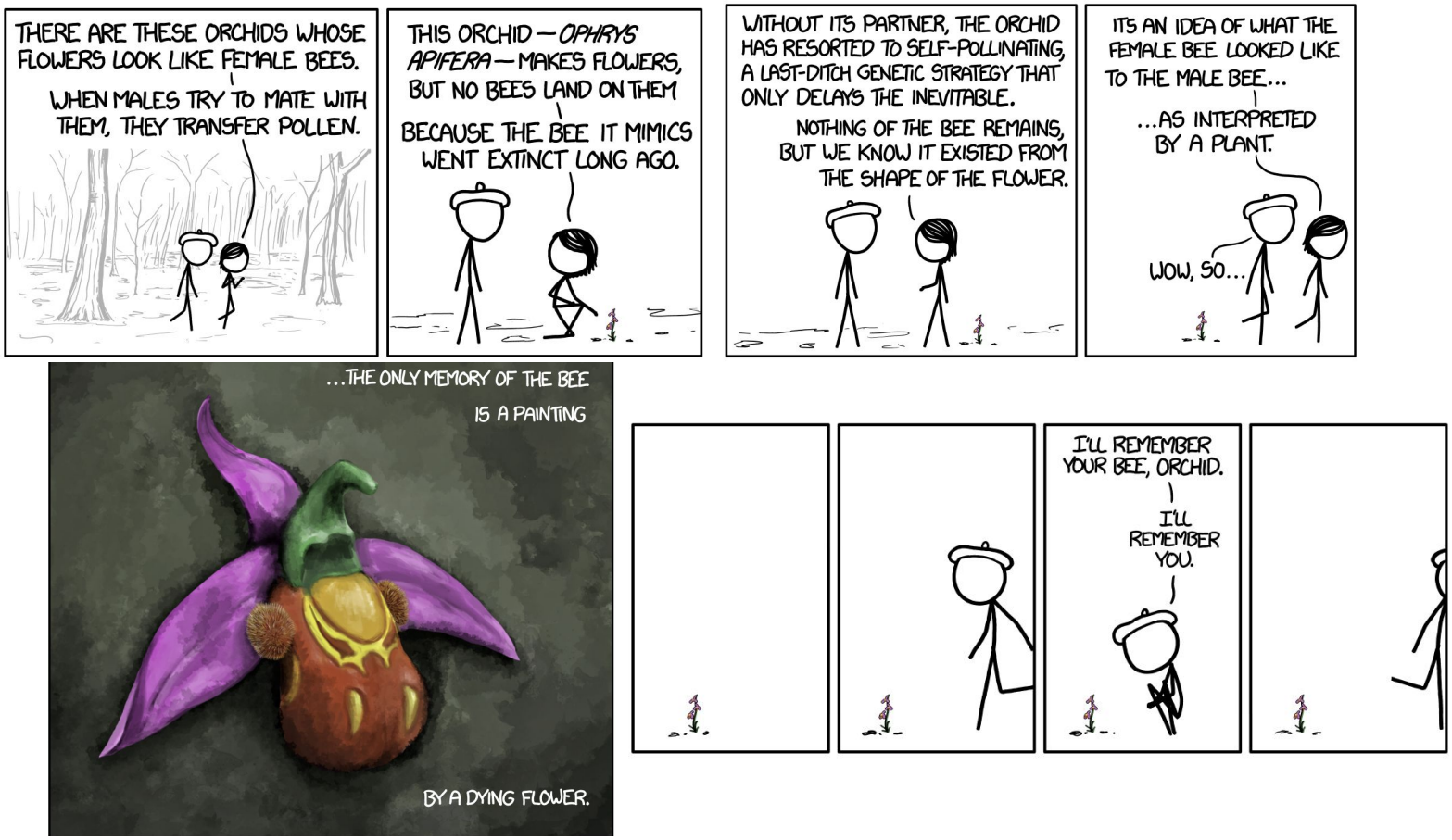
https://fiyahlitmag.com/ | https://www.sfwa.org/ | http://clarion.ucsd.edu/#apply

Environmental Justice & Finding Community in Nature

https://latinooutdoors.org/ | https://www.disabledhikers.com/ | https://www.communitynatureconnection.org/

Conservation & Ecology

https://conservationscholars.ucsc.edu/ | https://americorps.gov/ | https://www.nps.gov/aboutus/workwithus.htm | https://wfscjobs.tamu.edu/job-board/



In-Class (and from here on out) Reflections

1. How has your view of nature changed since the start of this class?

2. Where can you go to experience nature as you wish to experience it? Somewhere local and accessible to you on a regular basis.

3. When you tell your story about nature, what do you want it to say? How would you want others to feel after experiencing your story?

M50 INTRO TO VISUAL CULTURES, SECTION 1A

TA Kat Hernandez

Welcome! This google doc is meant as a group study and class discourse tool. I will be using it for in-class group activities, post-section study questions you can use to guide your learning, and to keep a record of some of the interesting observations & analysis we'll be exploring together.

This document is not a replacement for attending discussion! It is an additional participation and study tool. Nothing I post on this doc is a due assignment, but I will be observing our conduct here each week, so please be respectful in your contributions and of other people's. I have emailed you all my policy sheet for more detail.

Alright, let's all go to the movies! (*read with Regal Cinema jingle in your head here*)
~Kat

—--

Week 2

Discussion Clip 1 - 00:22:35 to 00:27:00

Post-class review questions: How do you all see embodiment here? Where does the camera seem to linger? How does Lane's embodiment interact with and comment on Brady's, and the story we are viewing?

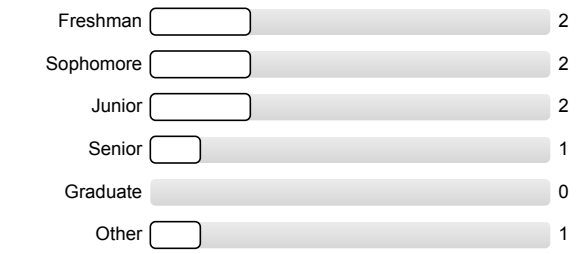
- While watching his past clip, Lane crinkles his nose and seems to smile → represents how learning to live with his impairment, rather than overcome it, has allowed him to reminisce on the past of him living his dream without bitterness
    - Brady's eyebrows make him seem sad while Lane in the video says he could never imagine living without bull riding, representing how because Brady hasn't fully accepted the idea of living with an impairment, he cannot fully accept the idea that living his dream of being a rodeo star is in the past, and that moving on is the best idea

- Henry Li: Lane can represent the physical embodiment of the real-life consequences of the rodeo lifestyle, something that Brady is beginning to see.
    - The camera lingers deeply towards Brady's facial expressions in almost every scene, beginning with him taking care of the horse and also with Lane, hinting that he is thinking deeply about his own passion but also his safety.

K.V. HERNANDEZ
Evaluation of Instruction Program Report
23F: ENVIRON M30 DIS 1B: ENVIRON LIT&CULTURE
No. of responses = 8
Enrollment = 11
Response Rate = 72.73%

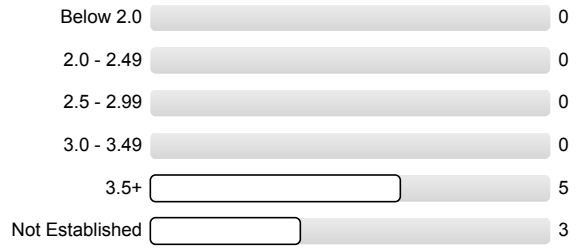
1. Background Information:

1.1) Year in School:



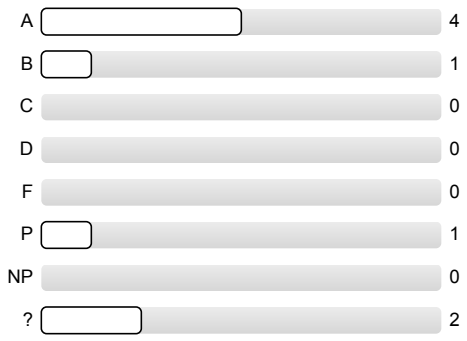
n=8

1.2) UCLA GPA:



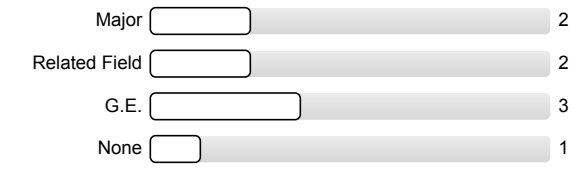
n=8

1.3) Expected Grade:



n=8

1.4) What requirements does this course fulfill?



n=8

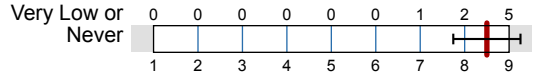
2. To What Extent Do You Feel That:

2.1) Teaching Assistant Knowledge – The T.A. was knowledgeable about the material.



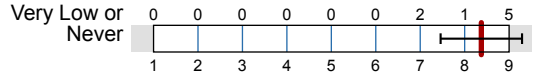
n=8
av.=8.5
md=9
dev.=0.76

2.2) Teaching Assistant Concern – The T. A. was concerned about student learning.



n=8
av.=8.5
md=9
dev.=0.76

2.3) Organization – Section presentations were well prepared and organized.



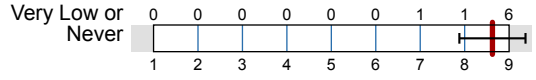
n=8
av.=8.38
md=9
dev.=0.92

2.4) Scope – The teaching assistant expanded on course ideas.



n=8
av.=8.38
md=9
dev.=1.19

2.5) Interaction – Students felt welcome in seeking help in or outside of the class.



n=8
av.=8.63
md=9
dev.=0.74

2.6) Communication Skills – The teaching assistant had good communication skills.



n=8
av.=8.63
md=9
dev.=0.74

2.7) Value – The overall value of the sections justified your time and effort.



n=8
av.=8.13
md=9
dev.=1.25

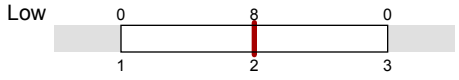
2.8) Overall – What is your overall rating of the teaching assistant?



n=8
av.=8.5
md=9
dev.=0.76

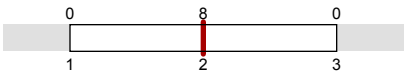
3. Your View of Section Characteristics:

3.1) Difficulty (relative to other courses)



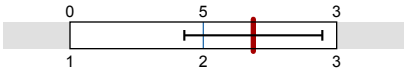
n=8
av.=2
md=2
dev.=0

3.2) Workload/pace was

Too Slow  Too Much

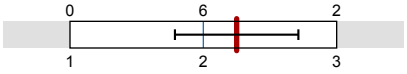
n=8
av.=2
md=2
dev.=0

3.3) Integration of section with course was

Poor  Excellent

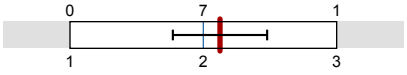
n=8
av.=2.38
md=2
dev.=0.52

3.4) Texts, required readings

Poor  Excellent

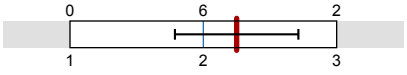
n=8
av.=2.25
md=2
dev.=0.46

3.5) Homework assignments

Poor  Excellent

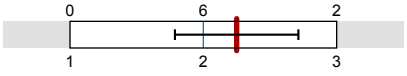
n=8
av.=2.13
md=2
dev.=0.35

3.6) Graded materials, examinations

Poor  Excellent

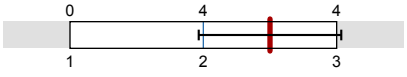
n=8
av.=2.25
md=2
dev.=0.46

3.7) Lecture presentations

Poor  Excellent

n=8
av.=2.25
md=2
dev.=0.46

3.8) Class discussions

Poor  Excellent

n=8
av.=2.5
md=2.5
dev.=0.53

4. Comments:

4.1) Please identify what you perceive to be the real strengths and weaknesses of this teaching assistant and course.

- I believe that Kat is great in the way that she's very knowledgeable of the course ideas, and also quite friendly and helpful. I also love how she fosters an engaging, collaborative discussion environment during our sections with her, where we feel very welcome and incentivized to share our ideas about the lecture ideas and readings/videos that were assigned each week. As for weaknesses, I don't think she has any real weaknesses as a TA; she's strong across the board in that regard.
- I really enjoyed coming to discussion, despite its early hours. I felt that Kat was extremely knowledgeable on the subject matter, and coming to discussion helped synthesized the material greatly, since often lectures could cover a lot of content at once. In felt like there was always support available from my TA, and she asked great guiding questions throughout discussion. I just wish there was more practice questions/prompts for the midterm/final, so I could have felt more prepared.
- I really liked having Kat as my TA, she is very knowledgeable and helpful. I think communication is a strong skill of hers and I appreciate her responsiveness when writing emails as well as communicating ideas within the discussion section.
- I think Kat was a great TA in terms of her ability to address and present new ways of thinking about the topics already discussed in lecture -- though I think there could be some work done in terms of steering discussions into new avenues instead of simply adding to the conservation point, her contributions were always helpful. I also think that there could be some work done in the communication department,

especially letting students know that she is available for office hours or willing to help on papers or any other relevant course material -- she is definitely great in office hours once you get into them, but it does feel like a slight barrier exists when it comes to reaching out for help.

- My TA was an extremely knowledgeable, passionate teacher who did her best in ensuring that we understood the material. She always made the effort for us to think outside of the box with discussions, and provided book recommendations to further learn about topics and concepts. I have absolutely no complaints about her class and her teaching style.
- She was helpful in expanding the content of the course and covering the readings from class.
- The section class helped me a lot to check if I am on the right page, and also because the lecture is more of listening and taking notes, I was able to connect the knowledge outside and expand my imagination through section. The pace was a bit fast for me, which made me not able to react to the questions asked in class right after, but I think it was my problem of listening and understanding. Kat also was so kind and helpful when visiting office hours to clarify things or helping me with the essay. Thank you so much!

  I liked the book recomendation too!!
- kind, smart, wonderful TA

Profile

Subunit: ENVIRON
Name of the instructor: K.V. HERNANDEZ
Name of the course: (Name of the survey) 23F: ENVIRON M30 DIS 1B: ENVIRON LIT&CULTURE

Values used in the profile line: Mean

2. To What Extent Do You Feel That:

2.1)	Teaching Assistant Knowledge – The T.A. was knowledgeable about the material.	Very Low or Never	Very High or Always	n=8	av.=8.50
2.2)	Teaching Assistant Concern – The T.A. was concerned about student learning.	Very Low or Never	Very High or Always	n=8	av.=8.50
2.3)	Organization – Section presentations were well prepared and organized.	Very Low or Never	Very High or Always	n=8	av.=8.38
2.4)	Scope – The teaching assistant expanded on course ideas.	Very Low or Never	Very High or Always	n=8	av.=8.38
2.5)	Interaction – Students felt welcome in seeking help in or outside of the class.	Very Low or Never	Very High or Always	n=8	av.=8.63
2.6)	Communication Skills – The teaching assistant had good communication skills.	Very Low or Never	Very High or Always	n=8	av.=8.63
2.7)	Value – The overall value of the sections justified your time and effort.	Very Low or Never	Very High or Always	n=8	av.=8.13
2.8)	Overall – What is your overall rating of the teaching assistant?	Very Low or Never	Very High or Always	n=8	av.=8.50

3. Your View of Section Characteristics:

3.1)	Difficulty (relative to other courses)	Low	High	n=8	av.=2.00
3.2)	Workload/pace was	Too Slow	Too Much	n=8	av.=2.00
3.3)	Integration of section with course was	Poor	Excellent	n=8	av.=2.38
3.4)	Texts, required readings	Poor	Excellent	n=8	av.=2.25
3.5)	Homework assignments	Poor	Excellent	n=8	av.=2.13
3.6)	Graded materials, examinations	Poor	Excellent	n=8	av.=2.25
3.7)	Lecture presentations	Poor	Excellent	n=8	av.=2.25
3.8)	Class discussions	Poor	Excellent	n=8	av.=2.50

Name: Maggie Chapin

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

I had Kat as a TA for two of my classes. For one of those classes, she taught my discussion section. Now, she is my research mentor for an independent project that I'm conducting, and I volunteer to help her with her research.

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

In my Urban Ecology class that Kat was a TA for, she took over the lecture one day. She presented her research in a way that was engaging and aligned very well with the class material. Through providing a concrete example of the theory we learned in class, I was able to become excited and engaged with the course in a way that I previously had not. In that same lecture, she provided ways that we could become involved as students in her research and other similar opportunities. The inclusion of these undergraduate opportunities, along with her very well organized, prepared, and engaging presentation, exceeded my expectations of a research presentation and left me feeling really excited about the material and the real world applications. Afterwards, I became inspired to involve myself in similar research. I talked to Kat after class about becoming a research volunteer for her work. Since then, I've been involved in research that has allowed me to explore my interests and contribute to a meaningful project.

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

Kat always made herself available to students during class, after class, and in office hours. She made it clear that we can come to her with any concerns or questions about class materials. In one of my discussions, my group needed technical help from Kat often. When we brought forward our ideas, she always thoughtfully listened to us, then articulated helpful answers and follow up questions. She would always take her time helping our group, which I appreciated because of the technical nature of our work. Her assistance contributed to my group's success in that class, as each of our group members earned A's. I also found Kat to lead wonderful discussion sections. She always expanded on course material and knew how to help students or point them in the right direction. She aided in our learning by creating a participatory class environment where questions and collaboration was encouraged.

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

Kat has been a wonderful mentor to me; it's obvious that she's very concerned with her mentees' career development, education, and pursuit of knowledge. We have biweekly meetings to discuss the research progress, but these meetings also serve as career workshops and discussions for any career or environmental science related topic that we would like to discuss. My career progress has benefitted from her presentations about resumes, interviewing, job applications, and graduate school. I asked her to review my resume and she did so very promptly and with attention to detail. Furthermore, she informs us about research and job opportunities.

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

UNIVERSITY OF CALIFORNIA, LOS ANGELES

UCLA

BERKELEY • DAVIS • IRVINE • LOS ANGELES • MERCED • RIVERSIDE • SAN DIEGO • SAN FRANCISCO

SANTA BARBARA • SANTA CRUZ

INSTITUTE OF THE ENVIRONMENT AND SUSTAINABILITY
LA KRETZ HALL, SUITE 300
619 CHARLES E. YOUNG DR. EAST
BOX 951496
LOS ANGELES, CA 90095-1496

PHONE: 310-825-5008
FAX: 310-825-9663
http://www.ioes.ucla.edu

Thursday February 12th, 2026

Dear Distinguished Teaching Award Committee,

It is my privilege to emphatically recommend **Katherine "Kat" Hernandez** for the 2026 UCLA Distinguished Teaching Award for Teaching Assistant. Kat was the TA for my Urban Ecology (Environmental Science 188A) course that I taught in the spring of 2025. It was only the second year I taught the course, enrollment was up to 70 students from 40 the year before, and I felt completely unprepared.

I was so grateful to have Kat as my TA—in a lot of ways she was more experienced and prepared than I was. She has an ideal temperament for teaching: she is relaxed and approachable, organized, and an attentive listener to students' questions. Students sought her out during weekly office hours and she patiently answered their questions. At the same time, she is firm and professional which helped her effectively enforce rules and grade fairly. One moment that stood out to me was the day of the in-class midterm exam. Kat confidently instructed the students to get up and leave their backpacks, phones, and computers at the front of the class. I had not even planned for this, but Kat knew what needed to be done and took the initiative. The students followed her instructions without hesitation. In this large class, I quickly realized that this was a necessary step to keep students from checking their computers and phones during the test. I'm sure that I learned more about teaching from Kat than she learned from me that quarter.

Kat's graduate work on urban wildlife was a perfect fit for the subject matter in my course. Kat delivered an excellent guest lecture on her research on media portrayals of mountain lions in Los Angeles. Her novel interdisciplinary scholarship inspired students to consider how culture shapes our relationship with nature. As a UC undergrad, and now a successful graduate student, she is also a relatable role model for undergraduates in her classes. As a TA, Kat is much more than an assistant, she helps the professor anticipate undergraduate needs, she understands the material, listens to students, helps fill in where the professor needs help, and truly elevates the quality of instruction that UCLA undergraduates receive.

Sincerely,



Andy Kleinhesselink, PhD
Managing Director of Sage Hill at UCLA
Institute of the Environment and Sustainability
University of California Los Angeles
Email: arklein@ucla.edu, cell: 541.973.1725